Strategic Partnership Proposal

King Abdulaziz University

National Preprint Platform & Research Excellence Initiative

December 2025

Submitted by:

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Table of Contents

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY 3

1.1 Partnership Principles 3
1.2 Strategic Objectives 3
1.3 Commitment to Research Integrity 3

2. LEADERSHIP TEAM AND EXPERTISE 4

2.1 Dr. Theeb Ayedh Alkahtani, MD MBE 4
2.2 Martin Delahunty MBA 4

3. THREE-TRACK ENGAGEMENT MODEL 5

3.1 Track 1: Technology Stack 5
3.2 Track 2: Platform Operations 6
3.3 Track 3: Editorial & Scientific Governance 6

4. PARTNERSHIP VALUE PROPOSITION 8

4.1 What KAU Provides 8
4.2 What KAU Receives 8
4.3 What Waraqa & Inspiring STEM Provide 8

5. NATIONAL PREPRINT PLATFORM 9

5.1 Platform Workflow 9
5.2 Platform Features 9
5.3 Research Integrity Framework 10

6. SUCCESS METRICS AND EXPECTED OUTCOMES 10

6.1 Year-by-Year Progression 10
6.2 Key Performance Indicators 10

7. IMPLEMENTATION TIMELINE 11

7.1 Critical Milestones 11

8. GOVERNANCE STRUCTURE 12

8.1 Steering Committee 12
8.2 Editorial Advisory Board 12
8.3 Research Integrity Committee 12

9. STRATEGIC ALIGNMENT 12

9.1 Vision 2030 Alignment 12
9.2 Long-Term Transformation Vision 12
9.3 National Partnership Strategy 12

10. NEXT STEPS AND RECOMMENDATION 13

10.1 Immediate Actions 13
10.2 KAU Commitment Summary 13

11. CONTACT INFORMATION 13

1. Executive Summary

Following productive discussions between Dr. Theeb Ayedh Alkahtani, Founder and Chairman of Waraqa Publishing House, and the President of King Abdulaziz University (KAU), this proposal outlines a strategic partnership to establish Saudi Arabia's national preprint platform with KAU as the anchor academic institution.

This initiative directly supports Saudi Arabia's Vision 2030 objectives and addresses the Kingdom's research integrity and international visibility challenges through a revolutionary three-track engagement model designed specifically for academic institutional partnership.

1.1 Partnership Principles

This proposal is structured to maximize KAU's academic involvement while requiring no financial investment from the University. KAU provides institutional recognition, editorial expertise, and academic credibility, while Waraqa and Inspiring STEM provide technology, operations, and international publishing expertise.

1.2 Strategic Objectives

1. Establish Saudi Arabia's first nationally recognized preprint platform
2. Position KAU as the leading academic anchor for research integrity and scientific governance
3. Create infrastructure for research dissemination aligned with Vision 2030
4. Build comprehensive local capacity for sustainable publishing excellence
5. Rebuild and enhance Saudi Arabia's international research reputation

1.3 Commitment to Research Integrity

In response to recent challenges in Saudi research reputation, our approach prioritizes research integrity above all metrics, implementing:

- Zero-tolerance policies for publication misconduct
- Comprehensive COPE and ICMJE compliance across all participating activities
- Ethical citation practices with strict self-citation monitoring
- Transparent quality assurance with continuous improvement protocols

2. Leadership Team and Expertise

Our consortium brings together the optimal combination of local expertise and international excellence required for successful implementation.

2.1 Dr. Theeb Ayedh Alkahtani, MD MBE

Founder and Chairman, Waraqa Publishing House

Dr. Alkahtani is a Harvard-trained bioethicist, physician, and health innovation entrepreneur with more than 15 years of experience building integrated research, publishing, and digital health ecosystems in Saudi Arabia. He combines deep clinical knowledge with expertise in research ethics, data governance, and scientific publishing to design solutions grounded in global standards yet fully aligned with Saudi regulatory and institutional realities.

As Founder and Chairman of Waraqa Publishing House, he leads the development of a national scientific publishing hub supporting peer-reviewed journals, AI-powered research integrity tools, and real-world evidence workflows. His work focuses on strengthening research quality, transparency, and discoverability across Saudi universities and research centers.

Dr. Alkahtani also founded Theeb Medical Group, an ecosystem of companies advancing CRO operations, IRB and research governance, clinical trial infrastructure, digital health platforms, and value-based insurance models—giving him practical insight into the challenges and opportunities of implementing research systems within hospitals, universities, regulators, and industry.

As CEO of NAMA CRO, he oversees one of the fastest-growing national CROs, operating CTUs across multiple hospitals and supporting RWE clinical trials, bioequivalence research, registries, and AMR studies.

His combined roles as a publisher, bioethicist, CRO operator, and ecosystem architect position him uniquely to lead efforts in national research integrity, preprint governance, and the creation of sustainable academic publishing infrastructure.

Educational Background and Qualifications

- Doctor of Medicine (MD), with a foundation in clinical practice and research methodology
- Master of Bioethics (MBE), Harvard Medical School – focused on research ethics, data governance, and integrity systems

Professional Achievements

- Designed research integrity and governance frameworks for CROs, IRBs, and national partners
- Led development of publishing platforms integrating AI-based screening, metadata workflows, and RWE tools
- Advised national regulators including CHI, SCFHS, and Hevolution Foundation on research, ethics, and data policy
- Built a multi-entity ecosystem enabling scientific publishing, RWE research, CRO operations, workforce training, and digital health integration

2.2 Martin Delahunty MBA

Founder and Director, Inspiring STEM Consulting

Martin Delahunty brings over 35 years of distinguished experience in scientific and medical publishing to the Saudi journal development initiative. As Founder and Director of Inspiring STEM Consulting, he provides specialized expertise in publishing strategy, business development, and training services for publishers, professional associations, pharmaceutical companies, and technology services worldwide.

Martin has extensive leadership experience with the world's most prestigious scientific publishers, including Nature, Elsevier (Harcourt (publishing innovation and market development), and Thomson Science (global publishing strategy and technology integration).

Development of Saudi Arabian Journals

During the period 2014-17, Martin was Global Director for the Nature Partner Journals successfully launching two Nature-branded journals in partnership with King Abdulaziz University and one with King Fahd University of Petroleum & Minerals. All journals are now ranked in the top quartiles of their respective Journal Citation Categories.

Specialized Expertise

- Open Science Publishing Principles: Leading advocate and implementer of open access models and transparent research dissemination
- Citation Growth Strategies: Proven track record in developing and implementing strategies that significantly improve journal impact factors and citation metrics
- International Standards Implementation: Deep expertise in COPE, ICMJE, and other international publishing standards

Professional Organization Leadership

- Current President: European Medical Writers Association (EMWA)
- Advisory Cabinet Member: Asian Council of Science Editors
- Former Secretary: International Society for Medical Publication Professionals (ISMPP)

3. Three-Track Engagement Model

The partnership is structured around three distinct but interconnected tracks, each with clearly defined responsibilities and partnership roles. This model ensures KAU's central involvement in academic governance while protecting the University from technology investment risk.

3.1 Track 1: Technology Stack

Description: Investment-intensive software infrastructure including the preprint server platform, AI-powered integrity tools, manuscript workflows, and publishing technology systems.

Lead Partner: Waraqa Technology (with potential external technology investment)

KAU Role: Client and platform user; no financial investment required.

Inspiring STEM Role: Technical advisory on platform requirements, vendor selection (ScienceOpen), system specifications, and international standards compliance.

Component	Specification
Preprint Server Platform	ScienceOpen-powered with Arabic language support
AI Integrity Tools	SciScore, plagiarism detection, image analysis
Manuscript Workflows	Automated submission, review, and publication systems
Investment Responsibility	100% Waraqa Technology

3.2 Track 2: Platform Operations

Description: Managerial and operational functions including metadata quality assurance, author help desk, production services, content editing, and researcher outreach programmes.

Lead Partner: Waraqa Publishing with Inspiring STEM as international operations partner

KAU Role: Supporting research institution; contributor of researcher submissions; promoter of platform adoption among KAU faculty and students.

Inspiring STEM Role: Operational design, workflow optimization, international standards compliance, quality assurance protocols, and staff training.

Service	Delivery Partner
Metadata Quality Assurance	Waraqa Operations Team
Author Help Desk	Waraqa (Arabic/English bilingual support)
Production & XML Services	Discovery STM / Waraqa
Outreach & Engagement	Waraqa with KAU promotion support

3.3 Track 3: Editorial & Scientific Governance

Description: Academic leadership including editorial oversight, peer reviewer networks, research integrity committees, scientific advisory boards, and academic governance frameworks. This is the central backbone role for KAU.

Lead Partner: King Abdulaziz University

Inspiring STEM Role: Governance framework development, COPE/ICMJE compliance protocols, editorial best practices training, research integrity guidelines, and international standards alignment.

Governance Area	KAU Contribution
Editorial Leadership	Section editors from KAU faculty across disciplines
Peer Review Network	Access to KAU's international reviewer database
Research Integrity	Committee membership and oversight protocols
Scientific Advisory Board	Senior KAU academics providing strategic guidance
Journal Integration	Existing KAU journals as platform launch partners

4. Partnership Value Proposition

4.1 What KAU Provides

- Institutional Recognition: Official university endorsement establishing platform credibility
- Academic Accreditation: University backing for quality standards and research integrity
- Editorial Resources: Faculty expertise for editorial boards and peer review
- Research Integrity Leadership: Committee oversight and ethical standards enforcement
- Journal Portfolio: Existing KAU journals for platform integration
- Researcher Pipeline: KAU faculty and student submissions to the platform

4.2 What KAU Receives

- National Leadership Position: Anchor institution status for Saudi preprint platform
- Enhanced Research Visibility: Increased international discoverability for KAU research
- Research Integrity Infrastructure: World-class validation tools at no cost
- International Standards Alignment: COPE, ICMJE compliance frameworks
- Training and Capacity Building: Editor and reviewer professional development
- Vision 2030 Contribution: Demonstrable impact on national research objectives

4.3 What Waraqa & Inspiring STEM Provide

- Technology Platform Investment: Full capital investment in preprint infrastructure
- Operational Management: Day-to-day platform operations and author support
- Production Services: XML typesetting, metadata, and publishing workflows
- Research Integrity Systems: AI-powered validation and quality assurance tools
- International Publishing Expertise: 35+ years of global publishing experience
- Global Partnerships: ScienceOpen, international indexing networks

5. National Preprint Platform

The centrepiece of this initiative is the establishment of a Saudi Arabian National Preprint Repository, branded as Waraqa and powered by ScienceOpen's proven international platform. This repository will serve as the Kingdom's primary venue for early research sharing and research integrity validation.

5.1 Platform Workflow

The following diagram illustrates the dual-pathway publication model, contrasting traditional journal submission (3 months to 1 year) with the accelerated preprint approach (1-5 days initial screening):

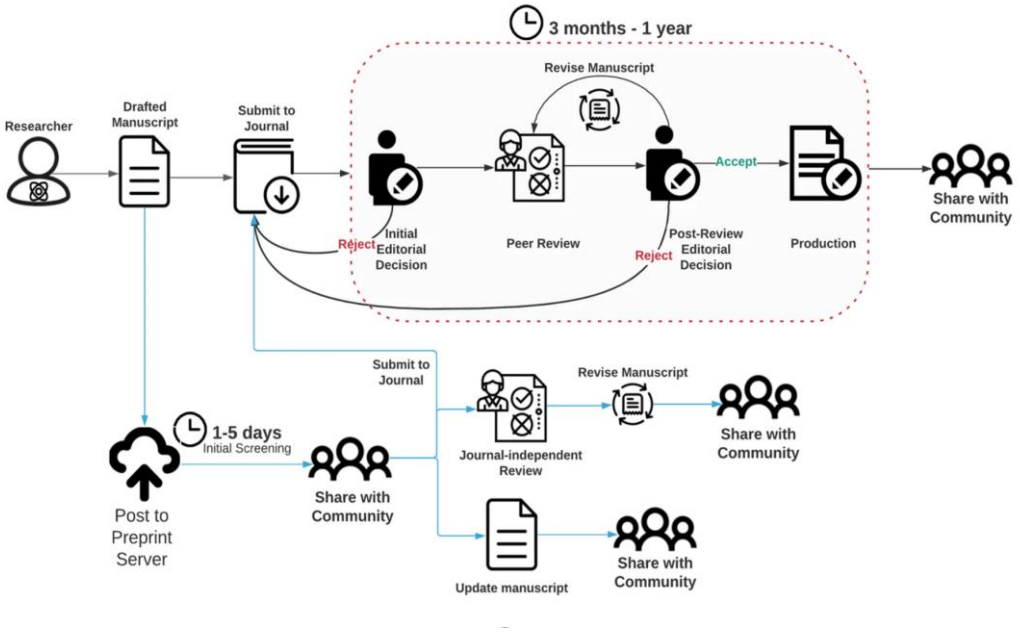

Figure 1: Traditional Journal vs. Preprint Platform Publication Pathways

Key Workflow Advantages

- Rapid Dissemination: 1-5 days initial screening versus 3-12 months traditional review
- Immediate Community Sharing: Research available to global community on posting
- Journal-Independent Review: Open peer review separate from formal journal submission
- Continuous Improvement: Authors update article based on community feedback
- Dual Pathway: Rejected journal manuscripts can still be shared and reviewed on preprint server

5.2 Platform Features

- AI-Driven Pre-Screening: Automated quality assessment and plagiarism detection before repository entry
- Open Peer Review: Community-driven transparent quality evaluation in Arabic and English
- Research Integrity Validation: SciScore integration for methodology assessment
- Global Discovery: Integration with ScienceOpen's 100+ million article network
- Bilingual Interface: Full Arabic and English language support
- Journal Integration: Pathway from preprint to peer-reviewed journal publication

5.3 Research Integrity Framework

In response to recent challenges in Saudi research reputation highlighted in international coverage, the platform prioritizes research integrity above all metrics through:

- Zero-tolerance policies for publication misconduct
- Comprehensive COPE and ICMJE compliance
- Ethical citation practices with strict self-citation monitoring
- Transparent quality assurance with continuous improvement protocols
- KAU Research Integrity Committee oversight

6. Success Metrics and Expected Outcomes

Our partnership establishes clear, measurable targets aligned with international best practices and Vision 2030 objectives.

6.1 Year-by-Year Progression

Year	Primary Focus	Key Metrics	Target Achievements
1	Foundation establishment	Platform launch, editorial boards	500+ preprints, 50% international board representation
2	Growth acceleration	Content development, partnerships	2,000+ preprints, 40% international authors
3	Regional leadership	Multi-university adoption	5+ university partners, regional recognition
4	National platform status	National recognition, sustainability	National preprint standard, operational independence
5	International recognition	Global visibility, self-sustaining	Middle East publishing hub status achieved

6.2 Key Performance Indicators

Metric	Year 1 Target	Year 5 Target
Preprint submissions	500+ articles	5,000+ articles annually
International editorial board	50% international	75% international
International authors	25% international	60% international
Research integrity compliance	100% COPE/ICMJE	100% COPE/ICMJE
Partner universities	KAU anchor + 2 partners	10+ Saudi universities

7. Implementation Timeline

Phase	Activities	KAU Involvement
Months 1-3 Foundation	MoU finalization; governance structure; platform specifications; editorial board recruitment	Sign partnership MoU; nominate editorial board members; establish research integrity committee
Months 4-6 Development	Platform build and Arabic adaptation; training curriculum development; reviewer network establishment	Provide faculty for editorial training; recruit peer reviewers; identify launch journals
Months 7-9 Soft Launch	Beta platform launch; initial submissions; quality assurance testing; process refinement	Submit initial KAU preprints; test editorial workflows; provide feedback for optimization
Months 10-12 Full Launch	Public launch; researcher outreach; national promotion; performance monitoring	Promote platform to KAU researchers; host launch events; ongoing editorial leadership

7.1 Critical Milestones

Milestone	Target	Success Indicator
Partnership Agreement Signed	Q1 Year 1	MoU executed with all governance structures defined
Editorial Boards Established	Q2 Year 1	50% international representation achieved
Platform Launch	Q4 Year 1	Full platform operational with 100+ initial submissions
Multi-University Adoption	Q4 Year 2	3+ additional university partners onboarded
National Platform Status	Q4 Year 4	Official recognition as national preprint standard
Self-Sustaining Operations	Q4 Year 5	Complete operational independence with knowledge transfer

8. Governance Structure

8.1 Steering Committee

A joint Steering Committee will provide strategic oversight with representation from:

- KAU: Vice President for Research or designated senior academic
- Waraqa Publishing: Dr. Theeb Ayedh Alkahtani, Chairman
- Inspiring STEM: Martin Delahunty, Director

8.2 Editorial Advisory Board

KAU will chair the Editorial Advisory Board with members including senior faculty from multiple disciplines, international advisors, and publishing experts.

8.3 Research Integrity Committee

KAU will lead the Research Integrity Committee responsible for ethical oversight, misconduct investigation protocols, and compliance with international standards (COPE, ICMJE).

9. Strategic Alignment

9.1 Vision 2030 Alignment

This initiative directly supports Saudi Arabia's Vision 2030 transformation objectives:

- Knowledge Economy Leadership: Positioning the Kingdom as the Middle East's premier scientific publishing hub
- Research Excellence: Creating internationally recognized platforms for Saudi scientific output
- Economic Diversification: Developing knowledge-based industries and attracting international research collaborations
- Human Capital Development: Building comprehensive local capacity for publishing excellence

9.2 Long-Term Transformation Vision

By 2030, Saudi Arabia will host a nationally recognized preprint platform serving as the Middle East's premier scientific publishing infrastructure, while simultaneously developing comprehensive research integrity frameworks that restore and enhance the Kingdom's international research reputation.

9.3 National Partnership Strategy

With KAU as anchor institution, Waraqa will pursue additional MoUs with major Saudi universities, alignment with national grant managers (Saudi NIH, Hevolution, RDI), and agreements with data providers—establishing the platform as the nationally recognized preprint venue.

10. Next Steps and Recommendation

We respectfully recommend that King Abdulaziz University enter into a Memorandum of Understanding with Waraqa Publishing and Inspiring STEM Consulting to serve as the anchor academic institution for Saudi Arabia's national preprint platform.

10.1 Immediate Actions

1. Schedule meeting between KAU President and partnership representatives
2. Review and finalize Memorandum of Understanding terms
3. Identify KAU representatives for Steering Committee and Editorial Advisory Board
4. Establish Research Integrity Committee membership
5. Commence foundation phase activities

10.2 KAU Commitment Summary

KAU's commitment requires:

- Financial Investment: None required
- Institutional Endorsement: Official partnership recognition
- Academic Resources: Editorial board participation, reviewer network access
- Governance Leadership: Research integrity committee chairmanship
- Platform Promotion: Encourage KAU researcher adoption

11. Contact Information

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